

Thorn in the THRONE

The clout that Yeddyurappa's protegee and Cabinet Minister Shobha Karandlaje wields has grown into a crisis that threatens to split the state BJP

By Stephen David

It is said that behind every successful man there is a woman. In Karnataka, behind a very successful woman now stands a stunned man. The woman is 43-year-old Shobha Karandlaje, a minister in the state cabinet. And the man left speechless is the state's first-ever BJP Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa.

Just over a month ago, Yeddyurappa looked unassailable after he led the BJP to victory in five of the seven by-elections to the state Assembly, converting his minority Government into one with a legitimate majority. Today, as the only BJP Government in the south reels under the impact of a self-inflicted crisis, accusing fingers are being pointed at Karandlaje and her proximity to the chief minister. In May 2008, when the BJP won 110 seats—three short of the magic figure of 113 in the 224-member Karnataka Assembly—the credit for luring six independent MLAs belonged entirely to the “Bellary Brothers”—Janardhan, Karunakara, Sriramulu and Somashekhara Reddy. Sons of a police constable, they worked their way up the business and political ladder to be counted among the richest and most powerful politicians in the state.

The crisis that grips the BJP Government owes itself to the alleged undue importance that Yeddyurappa has given to Karandlaje, a farmer's daughter from Puttur Taluk who is now a de facto deputy chief minister and virtually the second most important member of the state Cabinet. There has been plenty of evidence of

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